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NUR 101: Fundamentals of Nursing - Care, Assessment and Safety

The first-year foundations of safe, dignified patient care

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Health Sciences & Technology
Nursing Sciences | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Nursing fundamentals are assessed both in written papers and in the skills laboratory. This pack explains the nursing process, vital signs, infection prevention and patient safety, and includes a skills-practice log you can bring to demonstrations.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe the steps of the nursing process and apply them to a simple scenario.
- Measure and interpret temperature, pulse, respiration, blood pressure and oxygen saturation.
- Explain standard precautions and correct hand-hygiene technique.
- Identify common patient-safety risks and the nursing actions that prevent harm.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The nursing process

Assessment, diagnosis, planning, implementation and evaluation form a cycle, not a linear checklist.

- Assessment: collect subjective and objective data systematically.
- Diagnosis: identify the patient's actual or potential health problems in nursing language.
- Planning: set measurable, patient-centred goals and select interventions.
- Implementation: carry out care safely and document it.
- Evaluation: compare outcomes with goals and revise the plan.
- Documentation is part of care; if it is not recorded, it is treated as not done.

Vital signs and observation

Vital signs are the earliest warning system you have. Accuracy matters more than speed.

- Normal adult ranges: temperature about 36.1 to 37.2 C, pulse 60 to 100 beats per minute, respiration 12 to 20 per minute.
- Blood pressure is recorded as systolic over diastolic; use the correct cuff size.
- Count respirations for a full minute without telling the patient, to avoid altering the rate.
- Report trends, not single readings: a rising pulse with falling pressure is a warning sign.
- Record the time, site and position used for blood pressure measurement.
- Pain is a vital sign and must be assessed with a consistent scale.

> **Escalate early**
> A deteriorating patient rarely crashes without warning. Track early-warning scores and escalate according to your facility's protocol rather than waiting for the next round.

Infection control and safety

Most hospital-acquired infection is preventable with consistent basic practice.

- Standard precautions apply to every patient regardless of diagnosis.
- Hand hygiene before and after patient contact, after body-fluid exposure and after removing gloves.
- Use gloves, aprons, masks and eye protection according to risk; remove them correctly.
- Sharps go straight into a puncture-resistant container; never recap a needle by hand.
- Identify the patient using at least two identifiers before any intervention.
- Prevent falls: call bell in reach, bed at correct height, brakes on, clutter cleared.

The nursing process

Nursing practice is organised through assessment, diagnosis, planning, implementation and evaluation - a problem-solving cycle, not a form. Assessment gathers subjective and objective data; the nursing diagnosis identifies the patient's response to a health problem; planning sets measurable goals; implementation delivers care; evaluation checks whether goals were met.

The distinction between medical and nursing diagnosis is examinable. A medical diagnosis names a disease; a nursing diagnosis names a human response such as impaired comfort or risk of infection. Interventions follow from the response, so two patients with the same disease may need different plans.

Documentation is part of the process. What is not recorded is treated as not done, because the record is the legal account of care. Objective, timed, signed entries protect the patient and the nurse.

Vital signs, hygiene and safety